Body Doubling

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

Body doubling is when you work alongside another person to help you focus. The other person doesn't need to be working on the same task as you. Their presence simply acts as an anchor to keep your mind from wandering, and keeps you on track. It's a popular strategy used by many neurodivergent people to tackle boring or difficult jobs, such as cleaning.

Body doubling makes it easier to get started on a task. Having someone else in the room or on a video call creates a sense of accountability, stopping the feeling of isolation and reducing the urge to procrastinate.

You can try this with your colleagues by setting up quiet 'co-working' sessions. Just start a video call together, state your goals, and then get to work. You can also do this in the office by sitting near someone who's also trying to focus. It's all about sharing the same productive energy.

Useful Links

- The ADHD Body Double: A Unique Tool for Getting Things Done
- ADHD Body Doubling
- Neurodiversity Cafe: Body Doubling

Hidden Disabilities Sunflower

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

You've probably seen green lanyards with yellow sunflowers in airports, shops, or even at the office. This is the Hidden Disabilities Sunflower. While not exclusive to neurodiversity, it's widely used by the community.

Here's what you need to know:

- It's a discreet way for people to choose to be visible about having a hidden disability. This includes autism, ADHD, anxiety, chronic pain, and many others
- The wearer might need a little more time, patience, or assistance. It is a request for understanding, not a label of inability
- You don't need to ask what their disability is. Just knowing they might need extra space or time is enough
- If a colleague wears one (or uses a Sunflower background on calls), it's a helpful cue to be mindful of your communication and their environment

It is a simple symbol that promotes kindness and patience without forcing anyone to disclose their private medical history.

Useful Links

The Hidden Disabilities Sunflower Scheme

What is a hidden disability?

Infinity Symbol

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

If you've read the Puzzle Piece Symbol highlight, you might be wondering what symbol is preferred. The answer is (usually) the Infinity Symbol. It represents a spectrum of possibilities, rather than a line from less to more. Here's a quick guide to the variations you might see:

The rainbow infinity symbol represents the neurodiversity movement as a whole. It includes everyone with different types of brains, such as ADHD, Dyslexia, Dyspraxia, and Autism. The colours reflect the diversity of the human mind.

The gold infinity symbol is specific to Autism. The colour gold was chosen because 'Au' is the chemical symbol for gold. It's used to show that autistic people are valuable exactly as they are.

Unlike a puzzle, an infinity symbol has no beginning and no end. It implies a continuous journey and a life that is whole and complete. It rejects the idea that anyone is 'missing' something.

Adopting these symbols is a great way to show that you're up to date with the conversation and supportive of the neurodivergent community.

Useful Links

What is the Autism Infinity Symbol?

Key Terminology

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

Understanding words like 'neurodiversity', 'neurodiverse', and 'neurodivergent' helps us communicate clearly and respectfully. Since using the wrong term causes confusion, it's helpful to learn the differences.

The term 'neurodiversity' describes the idea that everyone's brain is unique, encompassing all of humanity. You'll want to use it when talking about brain differences as a whole.

A 'neurodivergent' individual has a brain that processes information differently from what's considered typical. Always use this word as an adjective, meaning you should say 'a neurodivergent person' rather than 'a neurodivergent'.

A 'neurotypical' person possesses a brain that functions in a way that society considers standard. This is simply the correct term for anyone who isn't neurodivergent.

You should use 'neurodiverse' only when describing a group of people with a mix of different brain types, like a varied workforce. An entire team can be neurodiverse, but an individual person can't be.

The word 'neurotypes' refers to specific categories of brain function, which include autism, dyslexia, and typical development.

Useful Links

Cleveland Clinic - Neurodiversity

Autism and neurodiversity

Masking

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

Masking is when neurodivergent people hide their natural traits to fit in. It's often a constant performance to meet social expectations. It's like wearing a mask to hide things like stimming or social anxiety. Here are a few reasons why it's a challenge:

- It's incredibly draining to do this all day
- It'll often lead to burnout and exhaustion
- It's hard for others to see when someone's struggling
- It stops people from being their true selves

You can help to create a more inclusive space where everyone feels safe enough to take their mask off, whether they choose to or not:

- Don't judge habits like avoiding eye contact or fidgeting
- Focus on work quality rather than how someone is socialising when assessing their performance
- Make it okay for everyone to talk about their needs
- Respect that everyone has different ways of working

Useful Links

National Autistic Society: Masking

British Psychological Society: Dropping the mask takes two

Meetings

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

Standard meeting formats don't work for everyone, often creating significant barriers for neurodivergent individuals.

- A grid of faces, poor audio, and noisy environments can quickly cause sensory overload
- Fast-paced discussions and vague rules make it difficult to keep up, which often leads to anxiety
- Forcing people to keep their cameras on means they feel pressured to mask, causing immense exhaustion and focus fatigue

Creating an inclusive meeting culture is essential for collaboration, and simple adjustments make a huge difference.

- Send a clear agenda 24 hours in advance, state the meeting goals, and make cameras completely optional
- Normalise using the chat function, stick to scheduled times, and include breaks for sessions over an hour
- Use the meeting invite template in the Inclusion Toolkit, and consider making a neuroinclusive meeting guide

Useful Links

Inclusion Toolkit home page

Meeting Invite Template

Neurospicy

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

While the slang term 'neurospicy' is often used with good intentions, it can easily become a barrier to clear, respectful, and professional communication.

The word can trivialise real challenges, sound childish, and frustrate adults who want to be taken seriously at work.

It's an 'in-group' term that can feel empowering when used individually, but it often feels disrespectful when used by outsiders.

You should always follow a person's lead if they choose this label for themselves, but don't use it to describe colleagues or the wider community.

If you aren't neurodivergent yourself, it's best to stick to accurate terms like 'neurodivergent' to avoid causing unintended confusion or offence.

Useful Links

Is it OK to use the term ‘neurospicy’ when talking about autism and other neurodivergences?

Puzzle Piece Symbol

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

You've likely seen the puzzle piece used to represent autism. While common, it is highly controversial. Many in the autistic community view it as outdated or offensive. Understanding why helps you be a better ally. Here is a breakdown of the controversy:

It implies autistic people are a 'puzzle' to be solved or have a piece 'missing'. This frames autism as a problem rather than a different way of being

It was historically used by organisations focused on 'curing' autism. It represents an era where autistic people were talked about, not to

The primary colours reinforce the myth that autism is just for children. This erases the existence and needs of autistic adults

The community generally prefers the infinity symbol (rainbow for neurodiversity or golden for autism). See the Infinity Symbol highlight

Being mindful of imagery shows you are listening to the lived experiences of the community.

Useful Links

The Ableist History of the Puzzle Piece Symbol for Autism
The History of the Puzzle Piece

Sensory Series: Light

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

Harsh lighting can completely drain a person's focus without them even realising why. For many neurodivergent individuals, visual environments are often much more intense. Standard office lighting can easily trigger severe eye strain, migraines, or a state of constant anxiety.

Older fluorescent tubes are a common cause because they actually flicker. While most people don't notice it, some neurodivergent brains process this rapid pulsing, which can feel like sitting under a strobe light all day. Bright glare from a window or a screen that's too bright can also become an impossible distraction. It leaves the nervous system working much harder than usual just to cope with the brightness.

Adjusting the visual environment helps prevent the hidden exhaustion that comes from simply sitting in a brightly lit room.

Simple shifts in how workspaces are set up can offer huge relief. Letting people sit in dimmer areas or turning off overhead lights in favour of soft desk lamps makes a massive difference. It's also helpful to support colleagues who wear sunglasses, tinted lenses, or baseball caps indoors to block out the glare.

Useful Links

- Autism and sensory processing
- Creating Inclusive Spaces: Lighting for Neurodiversity
- Impact of Lighting on Neurodiverse Individuals

Sensory Series: Sound

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

Sound affects people in completely different ways. For many neurodivergent individuals, everyday workplace noises aren't just distracting; they can be physically overwhelming. This is often due to sensory processing differences, where the brain can't easily filter out background noise.

An open-plan office can quickly fill with noise from every side. Things like keyboards clicking, loud chats, or a humming air conditioner take up a huge amount of mental energy. Some people might experience 'misophonia', where specific sounds trigger a strong stress reaction. Others might have trouble understanding speech when there's background noise, which makes collaboration extra challenging.

Creating a workspace that's comfortable for everyone's sensory needs is essential for a productive team.

Colleagues can support each other by being mindful of volume in shared spaces. It's always best to move long conversations to a meeting room or a breakout area. Respecting when someone is wearing headphones is also important, as it's often their way of creating a quiet space of their own so they can focus.

Useful Links

Autism and sensory processing

Misophonia

Auditory Sensitivity: Signs, Causes, Overload and How to Help

Sensory Series: Touch

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

Think about how many things touch your skin during a standard workday. For a neurodivergent person with sensitivity to touch, the physical world can feel much stronger than it does for other people. The brain often can't mute these physical inputs, which turns minor textures into a source of constant distress.

It's not just about a scratchy clothing label or a stiff uniform, though those can easily spoil a whole afternoon of focus. The office environment itself can present unexpected problems. A freezing metal desk, a rough chair fabric, or a sudden breeze from the air conditioning can feel deeply unsettling. Physical boundaries matter a lot too, since an unexpected tap on the shoulder can easily startle someone's entire nervous system.

Creating a physically comfortable workspace allows everyone to put their energy into their actual jobs instead of just coping with discomfort.

Giving people control over their immediate environment is a brilliant first step. This might mean allowing casual, soft clothing or letting staff use their own desk mats and chair covers. Respecting personal space by avoiding uninvited physical contact is another simple way to help colleagues feel secure.

Useful Links

- Autism and sensory processing
- Autism Understood: sensitivity to touch
- Humber NHS sensory processing hub: touch

Spiky Profiles

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

A spiky profile is when someone is really brilliant at some things but finds other things very hard. This includes things that might seem simple to other people. For example, someone might be amazing at solving tricky problems at work but find it hard to reply to a basic email.

This is not about being lazy or not trying hard enough. Neurodivergent brains are wired in a different way. Some skills, like creativity, focus, and spotting patterns, can be super strong. But other skills, like planning, switching between tasks, or doing routine jobs, can take a lot more effort.

Knowing about spiky profiles can help us be better allies. If someone seems to be struggling with something easy, it might just be that their brain works differently. Small changes can make a big difference. Try working with people who are good at the things you find hard, or think about how you share out work in your team.

Useful Links

Exceptional Individuals: Spiky Profile
What is the definition of a spiky profile?
What is the Spiky Profile?

Spoon Theory

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

Spoon theory is a way to explain living with limited energy. A writer named Christine Miserandino created it to describe chronic illness, in her essay, The Spoon Theory (PDF), but the neurodivergent community uses it a lot now.

Imagine you start the day with twelve spoons, but a colleague might start with twenty. Every single task costs spoons, like getting dressed or answering an email. However, a task that takes one spoon for you might take four spoons for someone else. Once you're out of spoons, you've got no energy left for anything else. You can sometimes borrow spoons from tomorrow if you really need to, but that leaves you at serious risk of burnout.

Spoon Theory shows how everyday tasks drain us differently. For neurodivergent people, things like sensory overload or masking can steal multiple spoons at once. The theory gives people a simple way to communicate when they've got nothing left to give.

Everyone should be able to manage their energy without shame. You can help support your team by respecting when a colleague says they're 'low on spoons'. It's also best to keep meetings short so you don't drain someone's entire supply. Please remember that energy levels change from day to day.

Useful Links

- Spoon theory: Understanding energy for neurodivergent people
- Spoon Theory for Autism and ADHD: The Neurodivergent Spoon Drawer
- Energy accounting: a strategy for supporting wellbeing

Superpowers Debate

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

Calling neurodivergence a 'superpower' is usually well-intentioned, but the community has mixed feelings about it. While it's great to celebrate strengths, this phrasing can create unintended barriers.

It can hide the hard parts of daily life. Focusing only on special talents risks ignoring the practical support, adjustments, and accommodations that people actually need.

This label creates intense pressure to be amazing. People can feel like they have to be a genius or extraordinary just to be accepted by those around them.

The term doesn't fit everyone's experience. Many individuals view their neurodivergence as a disability rather than a special power, so don't force the label on them.

Always let the person decide how they want to describe themselves. It's much better to compliment specific skills, such as great focus, creative thinking, and problem solving.

It's vital to offer support regardless of performance. Ensure people feel valued for who they are, even on the days when they don't feel particularly spectacular.

Useful Links

- From Deficit To Superpowers: Is It Ableist To Focus On Neurodivergent Strengths?
- Beyond Stigmas and Superpowers: A Balanced Neurodivergence Narrative
- Musing on ableism, neurodiversity, shame and superpowers

Tourette's Syndrome

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

Tourette's Syndrome (or Tourette Syndrome, in more medical settings) is a condition that's often misunderstood. Many people think that it's just about swearing, but that's actually quite rare (it's called coprolalia). It's mostly about tics, which are sounds or movements that someone can't easily stop.

It's important to remember that managing tics all day can be exhausting. Tics can increase when someone is stressed or tired, and trying to hide those tics can make it more difficult to focus. On top of this, other people can be judgemental about Tourette's, especially when they don't understand that it's not voluntary.

So how can you be a good ally to someone who has Tourette's Syndrome?

- Don't draw any attention to their tics
- Be patient if a tic happens during a conversation
- Focus on what the person is saying rather than the sounds
- Remember that tics aren't a choice or a habit, and the person can't choose how their tics show up

Useful Links

NHS: Tourette Syndrome

Coprolalia